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RESEARCH

Securitising AI: routine exceptionality and digital governance in the Gulf

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Abstract
This article examines how Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) states securitise artificial intelligence (AI) through discourses and infrastructures that fuse modernisation with regime resilience. Drawing on securitisation theory (Buzan et al., 1998; Balzacq, 2011) and critical security studies, it analyses national strategies, surveillance systems, and mega-event governance in Qatar, the UAE, and Saudi Arabia. It argues that AI functions as both a legitimising narrative and a technology of control, embedding predictive policing and biometric surveillance within public–private assemblages. The study situates these developments within global AI politics, demonstrating how external chokepoints, ethical frameworks, and vendor ecosystems shape the Gulf's evolving security governance, leading to empirical effects such as the normalisation of exceptional measures in everyday administration.

Keywords Gulf states · Artificial intelligence · Securitisation · Surveillance · Digital governance · Security governance · AI ethics · Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC)

1 Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) has become both a governing technology and a political discourse across the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) states.[1] In the past decade, AI has been framed as essential to national security, efficiency, and modernisation. Ministries, police commands, and sovereign funds alike describe AI as a transformative solution to crime prevention, terrorism, cyber risks, and mega-event management.[2] Yet beneath the language of innovation and progress lies a deeper political process: the *securitisation* of AI.[3] Through speech acts and infrastructures, Gulf governments construct AI not merely as a developmental tool but as an indispensable security asset that justifies extraordinary measures and normalises routine surveillance.

This article asks: **how is artificial intelligence securitised across Gulf governance regimes, through what practices and infrastructures, and with what empirical and normative effects?** This central research question structures the analysis. Drawing on securitisation theory which posits that issues are framed as existential threats requiring exceptional responses and critical security studies, it argues that AI in the Gulf functions as both a *discursive* and an *infrastructural* form of securitisation.[4] Discursively, political and bureaucratic actors invoke AI as a technology of safety, efficiency, and global competitiveness to legitimise new surveillance powers. Infrastructurally, smart-city platforms, biometric systems, and predictive analytics embed these narratives into the everyday administration of populations, producing what this paper terms *routine exceptionality*—a condition where exceptional security measures become normal governance.[5]

[1] Zuboff, Shoshana. *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*. London: Profile Books, 2019. esp. pp. 377–383.

[2] Lyon, David. *Surveillance Studies: An Overview*. Cambridge: Polity, 2007, pp. 89–96.

[3] Shires, James. "The Implementation of Digital Surveillance Infrastructures in the Gulf." *POMEPS Studies* 43 (2021): 59–65.

[4] Buzan, Barry, Ole Wæver, and Jaap de Wilde. *Security: A New Framework for Analysis*. Boulder, CO: Lynne Rienner, 1998.

[5] The year 2016 marks an inflection point in Gulf AI securitisation. In the UAE, the Abu Dhabi Monitoring and Control Centre (ADMCC) launched the Falcon Eye system, integrating CCTV, biometrics,

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This process unfolds within a distinctive geopolitical and economic environment. The Gulf's AI trajectories are shaped by international vendor ecosystems and choke-points in compute, data, and expertise.[6] Export controls, cloud partnerships, and normative regimes (from the EU AI Act and NATO's AI Principles to UNESCO's Ethics of AI Recommendation) define what is deployable, legitimate, or contestable. The Gulf thus serves simultaneously as a site of experimentation and a vector of diffusion in the global politics of AI: adopting and adapting technologies that mirror global security anxieties while localising them within authoritarian governance logics.

The article advances three interrelated claims. First, AI in the Gulf has been securitised as both a regime-resilience and modernisation technology, embedding predictive policing, biometric surveillance, and public–private assemblages that extend state visibility. Second, Gulf AI strategies are materially constrained and politically enabled by global supply chains and normative pressures—what this paper terms *infrastructural entanglement.* Third, the selective appropriation of ethical frameworks (UNESCO, NATO, EU) provides symbolic legitimacy without substantive constraint, exemplifying a form of *ethics-washing* that stabilises the status quo.

Empirically, the study analyses three emblematic cases: Dubai's *Oyoon* (municipal predictive policing), Abu Dhabi's *Safe/Secure City* (integrated surveillance), and Qatar's World Cup 2022 command-centre architecture (mega-event security).[7] These cases demonstrate securitisation's core dynamics: discursive legitimation (speech acts framing AI as existential) and infrastructural normalisation (material embedding of surveillance), triangulated through vendor documents, human-rights reports, and media investigations to evaluate claims and identify patterns of convergence.[8]

By connecting security practice, political economy, and normative governance, the article contributes to debates on digital authoritarianism and critical security studies. It demonstrates how AI transforms the modalities of control in Gulf governance, not by revolutionising state power, but by rendering exceptional surveillance routine, infrastructural, and globalised, extending Shires (2021) by showing *how* securitisation occurs through specific GCC infrastructures.

2 Literature and concepts: digital authoritarianism meets critical security

Efforts to understand artificial intelligence in the Gulf must be grounded in both the critical security studies tradition and the rapidly expanding scholarship on digital authoritarianism. Classic securitisation theory, Buzan, Wæver, and de Wilde (1998), defines securitisation as a process through which political actors frame issues as existential threats requiring extraordinary measures beyond normal politics.[9] This perspective has evolved significantly through sociological and practice-oriented variants,[10] which demonstrate that securitisation is enacted not only through speech acts but also through technologies, bureaucracies, and material infrastructures that institutionalise security practices.[11] In this expanded view, security is not a pre-given condition but an effect of political, discursive, and material practices that render exceptional interventions appear routine or inevitable.

AI's adoption in the Gulf exemplifies this dual nature of securitisation. Discursively, governments invoke AI as a guarantor of safety and progress; materially, they embed it in systems of biometric identification, predictive policing, and mass data fusion that institutionalise permanent surveillance. As Lyon (2018) and Ajana (2013) argue, technologies of surveillance are not neutral tools—they construct particular political subjectivities and social hierarchies.[12] This aligns with Ziadah's (2021) analysis of racial and citizenship-based sorting in UAE surveillance systems.[13] In the Gulf context, this means translating the promise of efficiency into the practice of control. AI-driven visibility operates as both a mechanism of governance and a mode of legitimation.

The Gulf's technological governance also aligns with global trends in *digital authoritarianism*—defined as how authoritarian states leverage digital infrastructure for surveillance,

and predictive analytics at an emirate-wide scale. Around the same time, planning began for the UAE's National AI Strategy (unveiled in 2017) and the appointment of a Minister of State for AI, signalling a shift from pilot projects to state-level strategy. These developments coincided with advances in commercially viable machine learning applications, particularly facial recognition and predictive policing, that enabled Gulf governments to deploy AI across security infrastructures.

[6] Horowitz, Michael C. (2018) "Artificial Intelligence, International Competition, and the Balance of Power." *Texas National Security Review* 1, no. 3 (2018): 37–57. pp. 44–48.

[7] Horowitz, Michael C. (2018), pp. 44–48.

[8] Balzacq, T. (2011). *Securitization Theory: How Security Problems Emerge and Dissolve*. (ed) London: Routledge.

[9] Buzan, Barry, Ole Wæver, and Jaap de Wilde (1998), pp. 21–25.

[10] Stritzel, H. (2014), *Security in Translation: Securitization Theory and the Localization of Threat*. Springer Nature Link, pp. 11–15.

[11] Coaffee, Jon. 2014. "The uneven geographies of the Olympic carceral: from exceptionalism to normalisation." *The Geographical Journal* 181 (3): 199–211.

[12] Lyon, D. (2018). *The Culture of Surveillance: Watching as a Way of Life*. Polity.

Ajana, B. (2013). *Governing Through Biometrics*. Palgrave Macmillan London.

[13] Ziadah, R. (2021). Surveillance, race, and social sorting in the United Arab Emirates. *Politics*, *44*(4), 605–620.

censorship, and predictive control.[14] Feldstein's (2019) The Rise of Digital Repression documents how 20+authoritarian regimes have integrated surveillance and AI analytics into governance, often through Western and Chinese international vendors and public–private partnerships.[15] This directly resonates with Abrahamsen and Williams' (2009) concept of public–private security assemblages, where security is co-produced by states and corporate actors, blurring lines between governance, commerce, and security provision.[16] Gulf AI ecosystems—reliant on partnerships with Huawei (Safe City), Palantir (UAE predictive policing), and Microsoft (Qatar World Cup)—exemplify this hybridity.[17]

At the same time, AI introduces a novel infrastructure of prediction and pre-emption. The now-substantial literature on predictive policing demonstrates how algorithms amplify historical policing biases, creating self-fulfilling prophecies of criminality.[18] In highly stratified Gulf societies, divided by citizenship, class, and ethnicity, these systems risk embedding discriminatory governance under the guise of objectivity.[19] Predictive policing thus extends the logic of preventive security central to Gulf rule: governing through anticipation rather than response.[20]

A parallel body of work on *mega-event security* illustrates how exceptional surveillance infrastructures built for temporary spectacles, such as the 2022 FIFA World Cup in Qatar, often become permanent.[21] This extensive literature, spanning Giulianotti & Klauser (2010), Boyle & Haggerty (2009), Bennett & Haggerty (2011), and Coaffee et al. (2011), documents how 'spectacular security' for events like the Olympics or World Cups creates permanent surveillance legacies.[22] These findings directly inform this study's analysis of Qatar's Aspire Command Centre, where AI is both a spectacle of modernity and an instrument of enduring control.[23]

Finally, debates on *normative governance*, including the EU AI Act (2024), UNESCO's *Recommendation on the Ethics of AI* (2021), and NATO's *AI Strategy* (2021, updated 2024), provide the global backdrop for Gulf adoption.[24] Gulf states selectively appropriate these frameworks to bolster international legitimacy without introducing enforceable oversight. This selective uptake exemplifies what some scholars term *ethics-washing*— the strategic deployment of normative rhetoric to legitimise unaccountable practices.[25]

Integrating these strands, this article conceptualises Gulf AI securitisation as a multi-layered process: it is at once linguistic, technological, geopolitical, and normative. By synthesising insights from securitisation theory, surveillance studies, and the political economy of technology, this paper makes three contributions: (1) applies practice-oriented securitisation (Balzacq, 2011; Stritzel, 2014) to underexamined GCC cases; (2) extends digital authoritarianism literature (Feldstein, 2019) by documenting vendor-state hybrids; and (3) theorises 'routine exceptionality' as the empirical outcome of AI securitisation, the paper situates Gulf AI governance within wider debates about how algorithmic infrastructures transform the nature and visibility of power, demonstrating empirical effects through three case studies.

3 Securitising AI through practice and infrastructure

3.1 National strategies and institutionalisation

Across the GCC, national AI strategies mark the discursive and institutional consolidation of artificial intelligence as a domain of security governance. The United Arab Emirates'

[14] Shahbaz, Adrian (2018). *The Rise of Digital Authoritarianism*. Washington, DC: Freedom House.

[15] Feldstein, Steven. *The Rise of Digital Repression: How Technology Is Reshaping Power, Politics, and Resistance*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2021.

[16] Abrahamsen, R. and M. C. Williams (2009). *Security Beyond the State: Private Security in International Politics.* Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

[17] Grewal, Shaina, and James Shires (2021) "Corporate Authoritarianism: Technology Companies and the Politics of Surveillance in the Gulf." *Surveillance & Society* 19, no. 2: 150–167.

[18] Ferguson, A. G. (2017). *The Rise of Big Data Policing: Surveillance, Race, and the Future of Law Enforcement*. NYU Press.

See also: Brayne, S. (2020) *Predict and Surveil: Data, Discretion, and the Future of Policing.* New York: Oxford University Press.

[19] Freedom House (2023), p. 10.

[20] Al Boom, A. A., and Bin Khalifa, S. K. (2022). "Predictive Policing." M.S. thesis, *Rochester Institute of Technology*. https://repository.rit.edu/theses/11171/?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[21] Zeng, J., Stevens, T., and Chen, Y. (2019) "China's Digital Silk Road and the Global Digital Order." *International Affairs* 95, no. 1: 147–167.

[22] Giulianotti, R. & Klauser, F. (2010). "Security Governance and Sport Mega-events: Toward an Interdisciplinary Research Agenda." *Journal of Sport & Social Issues* 34(1): 48–60.

See also: Boyle, P. & Haggerty, K. (2009).

And: Bennett, C. J. & Haggerty, K. (eds.) (2011) Security Games: Surveillance and Control at Mega-Events. Hoboken, NJ: Routledge.

[23] Coaffee, J., Fussey, P. & Moore, C. (2011). "Laminated Security for London 2012: Enhancing Security Infrastructures to Defend Mega Sporting Events." *Urban Studies* 48(15): 3311–3327.

[24] European Union (2024). *Artificial Intelligence Act.* Regulation (EU) 2024/1689 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 12 July 2024 on artificial intelligence and amending certain Union legislative acts. *Official Journal of the European Union* L 339; https://eur-lex.europa.eu/eli/reg/2024/1689/oj/eng.

See also: NATO. *Artificial Intelligence Strategy.* Brussels: North Atlantic Treaty Organization, 2021; updated 2024: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/official_texts_227237.htm.

[25] Jobin, A., Ienca, M. & Vayena, E. (2019) The global landscape of AI ethics guidelines. *Nat Mach Intell* 1, 389–399.

(UAE's) National AI Strategy 2031, coupled with the establishment of the Minister of State for AI, framed AI as central to achieving "safety, efficiency, and global leadership" by 2071.[26] This discursive framing transforms AI from a developmental enabler into a referent object of security: a technology to be protected, governed, and leveraged for regime stability.[27] Similarly, Saudi Arabia's National Strategy for Data and AI (NSDAI), under the Saudi Data and AI Authority (SDAIA), embeds AI across critical infrastructure and public administration, explicitly aligning datafication with counterterrorism and public safety objectives.[28] Qatar's National AI Strategy (2019), developed with the Qatar Computing Research Institute (QCRI), advances AI integration into defence, policing, and urban management under its "Smart Qatar" framework.[29]

Collectively, these strategies constitute what Balzacq (2011) calls the institutionalisation of the security act—a process where discursive securitising moves (speech acts) produce material effects through new bureaucracies that operationalise AI as regime-resilience technology, directly evidenced by SDAIA, via its National Information Centre (NIC), powering Saudi counter-terrorism platforms, and by the UAE's 2017 ministerial appointment for AI.[30]

3.2 Infrastructures of visibility: *Oyoon*, safe/secure city, and mega-event command centres

The infrastructural dimension of securitisation manifests in the Gulf's AI-enabled surveillance architectures. Dubai's *Oyoon* (Arabic for "Eyes"), launched in 2018, fuses thousands of public and private CCTV feeds with AI analytics for predictive policing and urban monitoring. Dubai Police reported 319 arrests in 2018 via Oyoon.[31] Public messaging emphasises efficiency and modernity, while the opacity surrounding data retention, algorithmic bias, and oversight exemplifies Stritzel's (2014) notion of *infrastructural securitisation*: embedding exceptional surveillance capabilities (real-time facial recognition, behavioural analysis) within ordinary administrative routines.[32] *Oyoon* thereby fuses civic utility with security control—an archetype of what Abrahamsen and Williams' (2009) describe as a *public–private security assemblage*, operationalised through partnerships with mall operators and hotel chains.

Abu Dhabi's *Safe/Secure City*, coordinated by the Abu Dhabi Monitoring and Control Centre (ADMCC), expands this model through city-wide biometric and automatic license plate recognition (ALPR) analytic integration. The system connects ALPR, facial identification, and behavioural analytics into a unified command centre that enables *anticipatory governance*.[33] Officials justify this as "proactive safety," blending humanitarian and technological rationales to normalise algorithmic pre-emption. Such practices reveal what Lyon (2018) calls the *banalisation of surveillance*: the transformation of intrusive monitoring into accepted infrastructure.[34]

The 2022 FIFA World Cup in Qatar provides a vivid example of mega-event securitisation through technological spectacle.[35] The *Aspire Command and Control Center* integrated more than 15,000 AI-linked cameras with crowd analytics, drone monitoring, and biometric access control.[36] Marketed as "smart safety," the system's persistence beyond the event, repurposed for urban regeneration and ongoing

[26] Government of the United Arab Emirates. (2017). *UAE strategy for artificial intelligence*. The Official Portal of the UAE Government. https://u.ae/en/about-the-uae/strategies-initiatives-and-awards/strategies-plans-and-visions/government-services-and-digital-transformation/uae-strategy-for-artificial-intelligence?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[27] Albous, M. R., Al-Jayyousi, O. R., and Stephens, M. (2025), "AI Governance in the GCC States: A Comparative Analysis of National AI Strategies", *Journal of Artificial Intelligence Research* 82, Cornel University: https://arxiv.org/pdf/2505.02174.

[28] National Library of Saudi Arabia (2024). *National Strategy for Data and AI (NSDAI)*. Saudipedia: https://saudipedia.com/en/article/2878/economy-and-business/data-and-ai/national-strategy-for-data-and-ai-nsdai.

[29] National AI Strategy (2019) Qatar Ministry of Communications and Information Technology:

https://www.mcit.gov.qa/en/artificial-intelligence-committee/.

[30] Saudi Data & Artificial Intelligence Authority (SDAIA) (2019). *Royal Order A/471 Establishing SDAIA*. August 30. Riyadh: Kingdom of Saudi Arabia. https://sdaia.gov.sa/ar/default.aspx.

See also: GovInsider (2017). "UAE appoints Minister for Artificial Intelligence." October 20. https://govinsider.asia/intl-en/article/uae-appoints-minister-for-artificial-intelligence.

[31] Gulf News. (28 Jan. 2019), "How Dubai's AI cameras helped arrest 319 suspects last year.": https://gulfnews.com/uae/how-dubais-ai-cameras-helped-arrest-319-suspects-last-year-1.62750675.

[32] Gulf News. (2019, January 28). *How Dubai's AI cameras helped arrest 319 suspects last year*. Gulf News. https://gulfnews.com/uae/how-dubais-ai-cameras-helped-arrest-319-suspects-last-year-1.62750675.

[33] Lifeboat Foundation (2021, Nov. 26), How an AI-powered system helps Abu Dhabi rank among the safest cities in the world: https://lifeboat.com/blog/2021/11/how-an-ai-powered-system-helps-abu-dhabi-rank-among-the-safest-cities-in-the-world#:~:text=Through%20the%20integrated%20use%20of,Project%20at%20Abu%20Dhabi%20Police.

[34] Lyon, D. (2018).

See also: Gulf News. (2021, October 25). *How an AI-powered system helps Abu Dhabi rank among the safest cities in the world*. Gulf News. https://gulfnews.com/uae/how-an-ai-powered-system-helps-abu-dhabi-rank-among-the-safest-cities-in-the-world-1.83924233.

[35] Panagiotopoulos, V. (2022, November 3). "Soccer fans, you're being watched." *Wired*:

https://www.wired.com/story/soccer-world-cup-biometric-surveillance/.

[36] Social Media Exchange (SMEX) (2023, January 24). "Qatar's tech opulence during the World Cup placed digital rights at risk.": https://smex.org/qatars-tech-opulence-during-the-world-cup-placed-digital-rights-at-risk/.

crowd management (Gaffney, 2018), illustrates Boyle and Haggerty's (2009) concept of the afterlife of security infrastructures. Qatar 2022 thus demonstrates, not merely represents, a turning point in the normalisation of AI-enhanced command centres, with empirical evidence of infrastructure retention.[37]

3.3 Normalising biometric governance

Alongside smart-city platforms, GCC authorities are rapidly expanding the use of biometrics. Technologies that once were confined to national ID programs or border control, fingerprinting, facial recognition (FR) and iris scans, are being rolled out in everyday civic and commercial transactions. For example, Abu Dhabi's Department of Culture and Tourism announced plans to implement an emirate-wide FR system in hotels, for guest check-in and security, by 2025, illustrating how biometric identification is migrating into the hospitality and leisure sector.[38] Airports across the Gulf are deploying 'smart travel' systems where faces and irises replace boarding passes. Banks and telecom providers use FR for customer onboarding. These moves reflect Ajana's (2013) broader shift to biometric governance, where one's body becomes both passport and password in daily life.[39]

More controversially, Gulf security actors have shown interest in emotion recognition and AI-mediated behavioural analysis. Vendors have pitched tools claiming to detect stress or deception via facial micro-expressions or voice tone technologies the EU AI Act (2024, Article 5) prohibits in public settings as scientifically unreliable.[40] While no solid evidence confirms affective surveillance deployment, vendor marketing to Gulf states (e.g., Huawei emotion AI demos) signals a willingness to push AI boundaries in policing.[41] This blurs identification (who) with inference (what they feel/intend), risking cultural misinterpretation and bias amplification without validation.[42] Yet in the securitised narrative of Gulf AI, even experimental technologies gain footholds aligning with total visibility.

4 Vendor ecosystems, sanctions, and transnational repression

Global technology vendors and supply chains enable Gulf digital authoritarianism, often in ways that complicate accountability. Gulf states leverage a hybrid ecosystem of Western, Chinese, and Israeli firms, local resellers, and procurement networks to acquire surveillance tools despite intermittent Western scrutiny.[43]

Gulf states are not subject to broad sanctions, yet export controls and scrutiny have intermittently constrained supply chains. After the murder of Jamal Khashoggi in 2018 and revelations of Pegasus spyware abuse, the U.S. and Europe faced pressure to curtail certain surveillance exports to Saudi Arabia and the UAE.[44] This led to temporary halts: Germany suspended arms/surveillance exports to Saudi Arabia (2018–2019); the UK reviewed licenses; and the EU Parliament called for a bloc-wide embargo.[45] However, many restrictions lapsed by 2020, resuming "business as usual" amid geopolitical priorities.[46]

Still, Chinese firms such as Huawei and ZTE aggressively marketed "Safe City" packages across the Middle East, bundling CCTV networks, license plate recognition,

[37] Boyle, P. & Haggerty, K. (2009). "Spectacular Security: Mega-Events and the Security Complex." *International Political Sociology* 3(3): 257–274.

Shires, J. (2021). The implementation of digital surveillance infrastructures in the Gulf. *POMEPS Studies*, 43, 59–65.

[38] Biometric Update. (2025, April 30). *Abu Dhabi to integrate face biometrics in hotels in 'Smart Travel' ramp up*. BiometricUpdate. https://www.biometricupdate.com/202504/abu-dhabi-to-integrate-face-biometrics-in-hotels-in-smart-travel-ramp-up.

[39] Ajana, B. (2013).

New York Post (7 Aug. 2024), "*This airport will soon be able to automatically ID passengers using controversial new tech: 'No government should be trusted'*": https://nypost.com/2024/08/07/lifestyle/this-airport-is-leading-the-way-to-document-free-process-with-biometric-scanners/.

[40] Access Now. (2022). *Prohibit emotion recognition in the Artificial Intelligence Act*. Access Now. Retrieved from (PDF). https://www.accessnow.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/05/Prohibit-emotion-recognition-in-the-Artificial-Intelligence-Act.pdf.

[41] Harwell, Drew and Eva Dou (8 Dec. 2020). "Huawei Tested AI Software that Could Recognize Uighur Minorities and Alert Police, Report Says." *The Washington Post*:

https://www.washingtonpost.com/technology/2020/12/08/huawei-tested-ai-software-that-could-recognize-uighur-minorities-alert-police-report-says/?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[42] J. Buolamwini and T. Gebru (2018), "Gender Shades: Intersectional Accuracy Disparities in Commercial.

Gender Classification," *Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency*, New York, NY.

[43] Grewal & Shires (2021), pp. 186–88.

[44] Friedman, B. (2018), "The Khashoggi Affair: Whither the Kingdom?" *Foreign Policy Research Institute*: https://www.fpri.org/article/2018/12/the-khashoggi-affair-whither-the-kingdom/?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[45] European Parliament (2018). "Resolution on Arms Embargo to Saudi Arabia:

https://www.europarl.europa.eu/news/en/press-room/20181018IPR16536/meps-demand-end-to-eu-arms-exports-to-saudi-arabia.

[46] Friedman, B. (2018). "Khashoggi Impact on Arms Exports." *Foreign Policy Research Institute*. https://www.fpri.org/article/2018/12/the-khashoggi-affair-whither-the-kingdom/.

and AI-driven crowd analytics into turnkey systems often financed with concessional loans. A 2021 CSIS study documented Huawei Safe City contracts or pilots in dozens of countries, including Gulf states. In the UAE and Saudi Arabia, these include city-wide surveillance in Dubai and Riyadh, blending public safety with predictive control.[47]

Israeli and Western companies have supplied offensive cyber capabilities to Gulf regimes. Citizen Lab and Amnesty International forensically documented repeated use of NSO Group's Pegasus spyware against dissidents. Emirati activist Ahmed Mansoor's iPhone was hacked in 2016, while dozens of Bahraini activists' devices were compromised between 2019 and 2020.[48] Subsequent reports (2021–2023) confirmed Pegasus targeting UAE dissidents abroad and Bahraini journalists, underscoring ongoing use.[49] These cases underscore a transnational dimension of Gulf surveillance practices. Critics, exiles, and even foreign citizens have been targeted abroad with tools produced in nominally democratic states. This outsourcing of repression raises questions about exporter responsibility and gaps in global cyber-governance.

Beyond spyware, even ostensibly benign technologies enable authoritarian practices. Gulf telecoms and social media operators have been co-opted into surveillance through laws mandating data retention and informal political pressure. AI-based content moderation tools supplied by Western firms, designed to filter extremist content, can be repurposed to censor dissent. Freedom House's *Freedom on the Net 2023* report notes that governments increasingly exploit AI-powered moderation and disinformation, deepfake campaigns, automated troll farms, as part of their authoritarian toolkit.[50]

Unless procurement oversight, export controls, and corporate accountability are aligned with human-rights standards, authoritarian governments will continue to acquire cutting-edge surveillance capacities. While U.S. initiatives, such as adding NSO Group to the Commerce Department's Entity List (BIS, 2021), are important, they remain insufficient alone. A more holistic approach requires: (1) tighter scrutiny of reseller networks; (2) stronger global norms governing surveillance trade, perhaps expanding the Wassenaar Arrangement for cyber tools (Wassenaar Arrangement, 2013); and (3) investment in civil society watchdogs to trace and publicise these flows.

5 Geopolitics of compute: chips, clouds, and the Gulf as an AI hub

AI capability hinges on computing power, data, and talent. As U.S.-China tech competition intensifies, export controls on advanced semiconductors, especially AI-appropriate chips, are increasingly reshaping Gulf ambitions. On 17 October 2023, the U.S. Bureau of Industry and Security expanded the geographic scope of advanced-computing export controls. Because all Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) states are listed in Country Groups D:4 (missile technology) and D:1 (national security), licensing for high-end AI GPUs (e.g., NVIDIA A100/H100-class) is tighter, shaping Gulf access to frontier compute.[51] This reclassification signalled a broader geopolitical mistrust. Analysts argue this creates capability constraints, nudging supplier diversification rather than an outright embargo.[52]

5.1 Building technological self-reliance

In response, Gulf governments are pushing for technological self-reliance and diversification. Saudi Arabia and the UAE have invested heavily in local cloud infrastructure and data centres, with the UAE allocating $1.5 billion to cloud projects since 2022, often in partnership with Western tech giants like Microsoft and Amazon Web Services (AWS) favouring data sovereignty to ensure state control over data storage and processing.[53]

[47] Segal, A. (2021). *Watching Huawei's "Safe Cities"*. Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS). https://www.csis.org/analysis/watching-huaweis-safe-cities.

[48] Marczak, B., Scott-Railton, J., McKune, S., Abdul Razzak, B., & Deibert, R. (2021). *Bahrain government hacks activists with NSO group zero-click iPhone exploits*. The Citizen Lab. https://citizenlab.ca/2021/08/bahrain-hacks-activists-with-nso-group-zero-click-iphone-exploits/.

[49] Marczak, B., Abdulemam, A., Aljizawi, N., Anstis, S., Berdan, K., Scott-Railton, J., and Deibert, J. (2021). "From Pearl to Pegasus: Bahrain's Use of NSO Spyware." *Citizen Lab*. https://citizenlab.ca/2021/08/bahrain-hacks-activists-with-nso-group-zero-click-iphone-exploits/.

[50] Freedom House. (2023). *Freedom on the net 2023: The repressive power of artificial intelligence*. Washington, DC: Freedom House. https://freedomhouse.org/report/freedom-net/2023/repressive-power-artificial-intelligence.

[51] BIS U.S. DOC (2022), *BIS updated public information page on export controls imposed on advanced computing and semiconductor manufacturing items to the People's Republic of China* (PRC), https://www.bis.gov/press-release/bis-updated-public-information-page-export-controls-imposed-advanced-computing-semiconductor?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

See also: Middle East Council on Global Affairs (MEC). (2024, June 30). *AI competition amid expansion of U.S. export controls into the Gulf* (Issue Brief). https://mecouncil.org/publication/ai-competition-amid-expansion-of-u-s-ai-chip-export-controls-into-the-gulf/.

[52] Chavez, P. (2025), "U.S. AI Statecraft: From Gulf Deals to an International Framework", *Center for Security and Emerging Technology*: https://cset.georgetown.edu/publication/u-s-ai-statecraft/.

[53] Maccioni, F., Saini, M., and Saba, Y. (16 March 2025), "UAE to build biggest AI campus outside IS in Trump deal, bypassing past

Simultaneously, they seek Chinese and other non-Western partnerships, such as Huawei-backed 5G and cloud projects in Saudi Arabia's NEOM or Saudi cooperation with Alibaba Cloud for its National Strategy for Data and AI.[54] However, concerns over strategic alignment have prompted recalibrations. Notably, the UAE scaled back Huawei's role in 5G infrastructure (2023–2024) to safeguard vital U.S. defence linkages, including the F-35 jet program and intelligence-sharing agreements.[55]

5.2 Developing human capital

The Gulf is also building human-capital capacities. The Mohamed bin Zayed University of Artificial Intelligence (MBZUAI) in Abu Dhabi, established in 2019 and licensed in 2020, is the world's first graduate-level research university dedicated to AI. It attracts global talent and supports education across cutting-edge AI disciplines, graduating over 300 AI specialists by 2025 and collaborating with global firms like IBM, reflecting Gulf efforts to secure both computational and epistemic independence.[56]

5.3 Navigating a bifurcated landscape

Hence, Gulf compute geopolitics is a balancing act. States are becoming regional data hubs while navigating an increasingly bifurcated landscape where Western regulations govern high-end tech flow, often tying compliance to ethical standards like the EU AI Act's risk-based frameworks (2024), and alternatives from China or other powers carry geopolitical costs. Export controls, cloud agreements, and data-sovereignty laws thus become arenas of global negotiation, with long-term implications for both AI capability and normative governance trajectories: Western-aligned compute infrastructures may enforce rule-of-law and ethical imperatives (e.g., transparency, bias mitigation), whereas alignment with authoritarian suppliers like Huawei may reinforce unchecked AI governance modes.[57]

6 Normative contestation and global governance: law, ethics, and power

6.1 Civilian AI regulation and human rights

Civilian AI governance is advancing through regulatory experiments and soft-law frameworks, with implications for Gulf practices. The European Union's *AI Act (2024)* is the most ambitious, adopting a risk-based classification from minimal to "unacceptable" risk. Article 5 prohibits: (i) untargeted scraping of facial images for FR databases; (ii) emotion recognition in workplaces/education (with narrow medical/safety exceptions); (iii) biometric categorisation inferring sensitive traits; and (iv) certain *individual* predictive-policing systems (e.g., risk scoring based solely on profiling, location, or past criminality). Law-enforcement biometric ID is "high-risk," subject to stringent governance.[58] As with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR, 2016), these standards will have global reach. Vendors adapt products to EU norms, creating de facto benchmarks that influence Gulf imports, such as Dubai's Oyoon and Abu Dhabi's Safe City systems.

UNESCO's 2021 Recommendation on the Ethics of AI, adopted by 194 members, emphasizes human rights, non-discrimination, transparency, and accountability through impact assessments.[59] Gulf AI strategies echo this rhetoric. The UAE's (2019) AI ethics charter and Saudi Arabia's language on "responsible AI" mirror UNESCO's framework (e.g., UAE's Federal Law No. 34/2021 on data protection cites "ethical AI" but exempts security applications; SDAIA, 2024). The challenge is implementation. Are these commitments substantive or merely decorative to deflect international criticism?

Privacy is a key fault line. Global momentum pushes against mass biometric surveillance, (e.g., EU bans, municipal restrictions in the U.S.), but Gulf governments prioritise security and order. While Qatar (2016) and the UAE (2021) have data-protection laws, broad national security exemptions dilute their effect. International scrutiny during Expo 2020 Dubai (e.g., EU observer reports) and the 2022 World Cup (e.g., Norwegian privacy critiques) pressured Gulf authorities to rhetorically acknowledge privacy, UAE officials claimed

China worries", *Reuters*: https://www.reuters.com/world/china/uae-set-deepen-ai-links-with-united-states-after-past-curbs-over-china-2025-05-15/.

[54] Alibaba (2025), "Expand Beyond the Cloud: Saudi-operated." *Alibaba Cloud SCCC Operating Saudi Region*: https://alibabacloud.sa.

[55] Reuters. (2025, May 15). *UAE set to deepen AI links with the United States after past curbs over China*. Reuters. https://www.reuters.com/world/china/uae-set-deepen-ai-links-with-united-states-after-past-curbs-over-china-2025-05-15/.

[56] Mohamed bin Zayed University of Artificial Intelligence. (2025, April 9). https://mbzuai.ac.ae/about/.

[57] Muldoon, J., Valdivia, A. & Badger, A. (2025) The politics of artificial intelligence supply chains. *AI & Soc:* https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s00146-025-02625-y#citeas.

[58] European Parliament. (2024, March). *EU's AI Act: First regulation on artificial intelligence*. European Parliament. https://www.europarl.europa.eu/news/en/press-room/20240308IPR19015/artificial-intelligence-act-meps-adopt-landmark-law.

[59] UNESCO. *Recommendation on the Ethics of AI*. 2021. https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000379920.

"GDPR-compliant" measures, Qatar cited "fan data security", yet FR and tracking persisted.[60]

Discrimination is another risk. UN agencies warn that AI may entrench racial, gender, or class bias. In the Gulf, where migrant workers constitute over 70% of the workforce in countries like the UAE and Qatar,[61] vulnerable groups such as migrant workers (e.g., South Asian labourers) or stateless populations (Bidoon in Kuwait) could be disproportionately affected by predictive policing or algorithmic risk scores.[62] For example, Dubai's Oyoon system, which flagged 319 suspects in 2018, has been reported to over-police migrant-heavy neighbourhoods like Deira, potentially amplifying biases in historical arrest data.[63] Similarly, Kuwait's 2023 biometric ID program for Bidoon risks profiling stateless individuals without legal recourse, as algorithms may flag them as "security risks" based on their lack of citizenship.[64] Without freedom of information laws or civil society oversight, these risks remain largely unchallenged.

Gulf states enter global AI ethics debates from a defensive position, prioritizing regime stability and economic goals over rights-based compliance due to their authoritarian governance structures. Leaders pledge adherence to "international best practices" to secure legitimacy and foreign investment, UAE's 2019 AI ethics charter cites UNESCO principles, and Saudi Arabia's SDAIA aligns with G20 AI guidelines, but these commitments often serve to deflect human rights critiques rather than reform practices.[65] The risk of ethics-washing, the strategic use of ethical rhetoric to mask unaccountable practices, is high.[66] For instance, UAE's 2021 data protection law references "ethical AI" but includes broad national security exemptions allowing unchecked facial recognition.[67] To mitigate this, GCC states could adopt: (1) mandatory Data Protection Impact Assessments (DPIAs) before deploying systems like Oyoon, as per GDPR models; (2) independent audits with public error reporting to address biases; and (3) citizen-accessible oversight bodies. Globally, coalitions like Freedom House advocate stronger export controls on surveillance tech (2023), while expanding the Wassenaar Arrangement could limit dual-use AI proliferation.[68] These measures would enhance transparency and accountability, countering ethics-washing in the GCC and beyond.

For reformers, the central challenge is translating soft-law commitments into enforceable rules. Transparency, ensuring citizens know what data is collected and how it's used, and accountability, providing legal recourse for individuals harmed by AI decisions, are critical. This challenge reflects selective norm uptake, where Gulf states adopt global AI ethics rhetoric to gain legitimacy while avoiding binding constraints. For example, the UAE's 2019 AI ethics charter and Saudi Arabia's 2024 "responsible AI" framework cite UNESCO's Recommendation on the Ethics of AI (2021) to align with global norms, but national security exemptions permit unchecked surveillance like Dubai's Oyoon. The EU's AI Act (2024, Article 5), which bans high-risk practices like emotion recognition, sets a global benchmark that Gulf imports may adopt selectively, omitting enforcement mechanisms.[69] To counter this, reformers in the GCC could implement: (1) mandatory Data Protection Impact Assessments (DPIAs) before deploying systems like Oyoon, following GDPR models; (2) independent audits with public error reporting to address biases, such as migrant over-policing; and (3) oversight bodies allowing citizens to challenge AI decisions. Globally, expanding export controls on surveillance tech, as advocated by Freedom House (2023), could limit unethical AI proliferation, ensuring norms constrain rather than merely legitimise Gulf practices.[70]

7 Case study synthesis

The following cases illustrate AI-driven securitisation in the Gulf, demonstrating how discursive legitimation and infrastructural normalisation embed exceptional security measures into everyday governance, with empirical effects on privacy and social control.[71]

[60] Manancourt, V., Westendarp, L., and Kayali, L. (15 Nov. 2022), "Don't download Qatar World Cup apps, EU data authorities warn", *Politico*: https://www.politico.eu/article/qatar-world-cup-app-data-warning/.

[61] International Labour Organization (ILO). "Migrant Workers in the Gulf Cooperation Council: Statistics and Trends." 2023. https://www.ilo.org/migrant-workers-gcc-2023.

[62] Retained inline: "Bidoon, from the Arabic term 'without nationality,' are stateless Arab people, particularly prominent in Kuwait, who are descendants of nomadic tribes not included in citizenship rolls."

[63] Gulf News (19 Jan. 2019). "Dubai's Oyoon Arrests 319 Suspects.": https://gulfnews.com/uae/how-dubais-ai-cameras-helped-arrest-319-suspects-last-year-1.62750675.

[64] ECDHR (2025), "Stateless and defenceless – The Bidoon community in Kuwait":

https://www.ecdhr.org/stateless-and-defenceless-the-bidoon-community-in-kuwait/.

[65] IFEX. "AI Surveillance Implications in UAE." 2025 Report. https://ifex.org/uae-ai-surveillance-2025.

[66] Papyshev, G., Chan, K.J.D. (2025), "Fugazi regulation for AI: strategic tolerance for ethics washing." *AI & Soc* 40, 3475–3486.

[67] SMEX (2025), "AI Investments and Surveillance Risks in the Gulf.": https://smex.org/gulf-ai-surveillance-2025.

[68] Access Now (May 2022). "Prohibit Emotion Recognition in the AI Act.": https://www.accessnow.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/05/Prohibit-emotion-recognition-in-the-Artificial-Intelligence-Act.pdf.

[69] European Union (2024). *Artificial Intelligence Act*. Regulation (EU) 2024/1689:

https://eur-lex.europa.eu/eli/reg/2024/1689/oj/eng.

[70] UNESCO. *Recommendation on the Ethics of AI. 2021*. https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000379920.

[71] Balzacq (2011).

7.1 Qatar 2022: security spectacle and normalisation risks

The FIFA World Cup 2022 in Qatar offers a vivid case of AI-driven security governance and its ambivalent legacy. In preparation for the event, Qatar invested in the Aspire Command and Control Center, which integrated data from approximately 15,000 surveillance cameras equipped with facial recognition (FR) across stadiums and fan zones.[72] Advanced crowd-analytics software monitored congestion, queues, and disturbances, allowing authorities to pre-empt incidents. Officials framed the system as a "new standard" in venue operations.[73] International observers, including digital rights groups, likened it to a "big brother" platform, where turnstile entries and metro stations fell under algorithmic surveillance, aligning with.

From a narrow security perspective, the event was deemed successful. There were no major terrorist incidents or large-scale disorder. Yet the tournament entailed unprecedented intrusions into personal privacy.[74] Fans were required to use the Hayya mobile application for ticketing and access; the Ehteraz mobile application, criticised for expansive permissions, remained active but by mid-November 2022 was primarily needed for health-facility access. European data-protection authorities and researchers warned of broad device access and data retention risks (Amnesty International, 2022).[75] Authorities insisted the data collection was routine, but rights groups highlighted the risks in a state with limited privacy safeguards (SMEX, 2023).[76]

The critical concern is post-event normalisation. Mega-event literature shows that temporary surveillance infrastructures often persist (Coaffee et al., 2011). In Qatar's case, the nationwide surveillance footprint, including 15,000 cameras, has been repurposed for urban regeneration and ongoing crowd management, confirming normalisation (Gaffney, 2018; Springer, 2025).[77]

Qatar's experiment is also influencing international debates. Security professionals planning other mega-events have expressed interest in the "Doha model" of integrated command centres.[78] With support from vendors such as Microsoft, and potentially and potentially Chinese firms like Huawei, Qatar may export its know-how. Without parallel diffusion of robust privacy and oversight standards, this risks contributing to the global spread of digitally enabled authoritarian security practices (Feldstein, 2019).[79]

Qatar 2022 illustrates both the power and perils of AI-centric security. The event demonstrated how AI can orchestrate seamless mega-event security but revealed how exceptional measures become permanent, aligning with Boyle and Haggerty's (2009) "afterlife of security infrastructures." For policymakers, the challenge is to institutionalise sunset clauses and independent oversight for invasive technologies.[80] Absent such checks, Qatar 2022 may be remembered not only as a sporting triumph but as a milestone in normalising the high-tech panopticon, with command-centre practices, data-sharing templates, and algorithmic thresholds migrating into everyday policing (Bennett & Haggerty, 2011).

7.2 Dubai's *Oyoon*: predictive policing as municipal governance

Dubai's Oyoon program illustrates how AI-enabled surveillance embeds within city governance, extending predictive policing literature.[81] Launched in 2018, *Oyoon* was presented as a multi-stakeholder "smart" security initiative involving the police, state security, the Roads and Transport Authority, and even private sector partners (such as mall operators and hotel chains). It created a city-wide video

[72] Goh, A. (7 Nov. 2022), "Anyone who attends the 2022 World Cup in Qatar can expect to be watched by 15,000 cameras with facial-recognition technology", *Business Insider*: https://www.businessinsider.com/world-cup-monitored-cameras-facial-recognition-tech-qatar-2022-11?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[73] Panagiotopoulos, V. (2022, November 3). *Soccer fans, you're being watched*. Wired. https://www.wired.com/story/soccer-world-cup-biometric-surveillance/.

[74] Asokan, A. (16 Nov. 2022), Qatar's World Cup Apps Pose Privacy Concerns, *BankInfoSecurity*: https://www.bankinfosecurity.com/qatars-world-cup-apps-pose-privacy-concerns-a-20481?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[75] SMEX. (2023, January 24). *Qatar's tech opulence during the World Cup placed digital rights at risk*. SMEX. https://smex.org/qatars-tech-opulence-during-the-world-cup-placed-digital-rights-at-risk/.

[76] Al Jazeera. (2022, November 13). *AI at World Cup 2022 to check crowds, control climate*. Al Jazeera.

https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2022/11/13/eye-in-the-sky-ai-at-world-cup-to-check-crowds-control-climate?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[77] SMEX. (2023, January 24).

[78] AL-Dosari, K., Deif, A. M., Kucukvar, M., Onat, N., & Fetais, N. (2023). *Security Supply Chain Using UAVs: Validation and Development of a UAV-Based Model for Qatar's Mega Sporting Events*. *Drones, 7*(9), 555. https://doi.org/10.3390/drones7090555.

[79] ONEVILLENEWS / Messe Frankfurt. (2025, August 27). *Middle East mega-events require human-centric security models powered by advanced tech, say regional experts*. IFF Magazine.

https://onevillenews.com/2025/08/27/middle-east-mega-events-require-human-centric-security-models-powered-by-advanced-tech-to-be-protected-say-regional-experts/.

[80] INTERPOL. (2017). *INTERPOL and Qatar shape major event security* via *global network*. Interpol News.

https://www.interpol.int/en/News-and-Events/News/2017/INTERPOL-and-Qatar-shape-major-event-security-via-global-network.

[81] Ferguson, A. G. (2017). *The Rise of Big Data Policing: Surveillance, Race, and the Future of Law Enforcement*. NYU Press, 2017.

surveillance cloud, where feeds from thousands of CCTV cameras, government and privately owned, are funnelled to a central AI platform. The system employs facial recognition to flag wanted individuals or persons of interest, automatic license plate recognition (ALPR) to track cars, and behavioural algorithms to detect "unusual" activities in real time.[82]

The official narrative emphasizes efficiency and crime prevention.[83] Dubai Police credit Oyoon with 319 arrests in 2018 and rapid resolution of thefts and hit-and-run cases, alongside non-crime uses like traffic management.[84] This portrays *Oyoon* as a pillar of Dubai's smart city vision, delivering safety and convenience through automated monitoring.[85] However, *Oyoon* raises ethical concerns central to predictive policing. The public lacks transparency on how Oyoon's algorithms flag "suspicious" behaviour, risking bias amplification against migrant workers in areas like Deira, where over-policing is reported.[86] Without independent oversight, accuracy reports, or mechanisms to challenge false flags, these risks align with Ferguson's (2017) critique of predictive policing's self-fulfilling biases.

Moreover, *Oyoon* illustrates the bleed-over of counter-terrorism logic into everyday policing. Initially justified for serious threats, Oyoon's multi-agency structure enables function creep, where traffic cameras monitor protests or labour strikes, treated as security issues in the UAE.[87] The integration of cameras and databases reduces urban blind spots, amplifying state control.[88]

Dubai's populace, often described as trading privacy for security and amenities, shows little resistance, unsurprising in a tightly controlled political climate. Yet, this silence underscores the need to scrutinize Oyoon as a model, as Bahrain and Saudi Arabia explore similar systems (IFEX, 2025).[89] If Oyoon normalizes surveillance as an urban utility, public privacy could vanish, reflecting Lyon's (2018) banalisation of surveillance.[90]

Oyoon merges the smart city ideal, seamless tech for efficient services, with the security state's imperative of maximum visibility, encapsulating AI's dual-use nature: guiding parking while flagging suspects.[91] For global and local policymakers, balancing such systems with safeguards like independent audits and transparent error reporting is critical to prevent harm to trust and privacy.

7.3 Abu Dhabi safe/secure city: integrated biometrics for "proactive safety"

Abu Dhabi's Safe/Secure City initiative, led by its Monitoring and Control Centre (ADMCC), emphasizes proactive safety and response coordination, distinguishing it from Dubai's Oyoon. It adopts an all-hazards approach, addressing not only crime and terrorism but also disaster response, infrastructure monitoring, and pandemic enforcement e.g., during COVID-19, systems monitored mask compliance and quarantine).[92]

One hallmark of Abu Dhabi's approach is the integration of biometric access control into everyday transactions. For example, building access in government facilities and many private offices now uses facial recognition (FR) or fingerprint scans tied into the Safe City network. As previously noted, an emirate-wide FR check-in system for hotels, feeding data to the central system, is planned for 2025.[93] The system aims to authenticate individuals at key nodes, airports, hotels, malls, government offices, and camera-equipped parks, against security watchlists. and checked against security watchlists.[94]

[82] City Security Magazine. (2019, July 23). *Dubai Police take personal security to a whole new level*. City Security Magazine. https://citysecuritymagazine.com/editors-choice/dubai-police-take-personal-security-to-a-whole-new-level/.

[83] Gulf Business. (21 March 2018). *Dubai Police launches AI surveillance programme*. Gulf Business. https://gulfbusiness.com/dubai-police-launches-ai-surveillance-programme/.

[84] Gulf News. (2019, January 28). *How Dubai's AI cameras helped arrest 319 suspects last year*. Gulf News. https://gulfnews.com/uae/how-dubais-ai-cameras-helped-arrest-319-suspects-last-year-1.62750675.

[85] Trescon Global. "Dubai – A global hub for FinTech Innovation" (7 Feb. 2025). https://tresconglobal.com/news/5-reasons-why-dubai-is-the-global-hub-for-fintech-innovation/.

[86] Ziadah, R. (2021).

[87] SMEX (19 May 2025), "AI Investments and Surveillance Risks in the Gulf.": https://smex.org/ai-investments-in-the-gulf-opportunities-and-surveillance-risks/.

[88] Smart Cities World Forums. (2018). *Dubai Police launches artificial intelligence surveillance project*. Smart Cities World Forums. https://www.smartcitiesworldforums.com/global-coverage/smart-cities-mena/reports-and-coverage-mena/755-dubai-police-launches-artificial-intelligence-surveillance-project.

[89] IFEX (2025), "The rise of AI surveillance in the UAE: Implications for human rights" 2025 Report: https://ifex.org/the-rise-of-ai-surveillance-in-the-uae-implications-for-human-rights/.

[90] Americans for Democracy & Human Rights in Bahrain (ADHRB). (2025, April 17). *The rise of AI surveillance in the UAE: Implications for human rights*. ADHRB. https://www.adhrb.org/2025/04/the-rise-of-ai-surveillance-in-the-uae-implications-for-human-rights/.

[91] Mozur, P. and Satariano, A. (30 March 2023), "A.I., Brain Scans and Cameras: The Spread of Police Surveillance Tech" *The New York Times*: https://www.nytimes.com/2023/03/30/technology/police-surveillance-tech-dubai.html.

[92] Al Hanaee, M. (2022). Influencing police and community relations in Abu Dhabi: Legitimation through a soft power dynamic. *Policing: A Journal of Policy and Practice, 16*(2), 249–267.

[93] Al Hosany, F., Ganesan, S., Al Memari, S., Al Mazrouei, S., Ahamed, F., Koshy, A., & Zaher, W. (2021). Response to the COVID-19 pandemic in the UAE: A public health perspective. *Journal of Global Health*, 11, 03050.

[94] Biometric Update. (2025, April 30). *Abu Dhabi to integrate face biometrics in hotels in 'Smart Travel' ramp up*:

From a policing perspective, this makes evasion difficult for wanted persons. From a civil liberties perspective, it eliminates anonymity, raising privacy concerns.[95]

Another key feature is predictive analytics. Abu Dhabi Police use AI to map crime hotspots and predict traffic accident locations for ambulance staging, aligning with predictive policing practices.[96] Such predictions, if based on historical data or social media, risk embedding biases—e.g., over-predicting incidents in poorer districts due to higher historical police reports, creating self-fulfilling cycles.

Abu Dhabi also employs inter-agency data fusion. The Safe City control room integrates police, civil defence for fire and rescue, ambulance services, traffic management, and municipality representatives city municipality reps. This whole-of-government approach enables a single platform to track diverse events, from power outages to political protests. On one hand, this enhances emergency response efficiency. On the other, it concentrates vast data in one hub, amplifying risks of misuse or breaches. If authoritarian impulses emerge, e.g., to target dissidents, the system provides tools like CCTV tracking, state-linked telecom data, and AI-monitored financial records.

Despite these concerns, Abu Dhabi has earned international accolades, often ranking among the world's safest cities in perception surveys.[97] Authorities attribute this to technology, constructing a narrative equating technology with safety and modernity.[98] Challenging this requires evidence, scarce in the UAE's opaque context, that safety could be achieved less intrusively or that privacy losses outweigh safety gains. Such counter-arguments have gained little traction, given high citizen trust and a social contract trading freedoms for stability.

In conclusion, Abu Dhabi's Safe City underscores the slippery slope of well-intentioned measures. The integration of services (fire, police, ambulance) evolves into pervasive surveillance. While no abuse is documented today, future misuse risks persist, especially under shifting political conditions. The challenge for the UAE and similar states is implementing checks, audit logs, sanctions for misuse, to ensure accountability, preventing automated authoritarianism.

https://www.biometricupdate.com/202504/abu-dhabi-to-integrate-face-biometrics-in-hotels-in-smart-travel-ramp-up.

[95] Lyon (2018).

[96] FLIR Systems. (2018, September 25). *FLIR Abu Dhabi Safe City Project wins Security Infrastructure Project of the Year*. FLIR News Center.

[97] Gulf News. (2021, November 24). *How an AI-powered system helps Abu Dhabi rank among the safest cities in the world*. *Gulf News*.

[98] Times of India. (2025, July 21). *Abu Dhabi tops global safety list: What the world can learn from UAE*. *Times of India*.

7.4 Cross-border spyware and transnational repression

No analysis of Gulf AI and security is complete without addressing digital tools' role in transnational repression. The Pegasus spyware scandal is instructive. In 2021, Citizen Lab revealed that Bahrain's government hacked dozens of activists, lawyers, and parliament members using NSO Group's Pegasus zero-click exploits.[99] Earlier, in 2016–2017, the UAE targeted Emirati human rights defender Ahmed Mansoor's iPhone with Pegasus, costing hundreds of thousands per exploit—the "million-dollar dissident" case. Saudi Arabia also used Pegasus against dissidents abroad, including Jamal Khashoggi's associates, with 2023 reports confirming ongoing targeting of Bahraini journalists.[100]

These cases demonstrate Gulf states leveraging advanced AI, in a broad sense, as machine learning underpins Pegasus's data exfiltration, to violate global privacy. Pegasus's targeted, silent, deniable nature makes it more insidious than mass surveillance like cameras. Governments can cripple opposition by surveilling exiles in safe havens like London or Toronto without physical harassment, extending authoritarian reach.

Transnational repression is not new, historically, dissidents faced physical threats, but the digital dimension reduces political costs. Phones report locations and contacts, eliminating the need for physical agents.[101] As Gulf states invest in AI, advanced tools (e.g., diaspora network analysis or automated disinformation) may emerge, amplifying repression.

International responses to Pegasus are growing. The U.S. blacklisted NSO Group in 2021, and NGOs advocate a moratorium on private spyware sales.[102] Lawsuits, including Apple's against NSO and individual cases, are advancing.[103] Yet, demand for such tools grows as

[99] Citizen Lab. (2021, August 24), "Bahrain government hacks activists with NSO Group zero-click iPhone exploits." *Citizen Lab*: https://citizenlab.ca/2021/08/bahrain-hacks-activists-with-nso-group-zero-click-iphone-exploits/?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[100] Citizen Lab. (2018, September 18), "Tracking NSO Group's Pegasus spyware to operations in 45 countries." *Citizen Lab*. https://citizenlab.ca/2018/09/hide-and-seek-tracking-nso-groups-pegasus-spyware-to-operations-in-45-countries/

[101] Woolley, Samuel C., & Howard, Philip N. *Computational Propaganda*. Oxford University Press, 2016.

[102] The Guardian. (2021, November 3). *US blacklists Israeli firm NSO after Pegasus spyware scandal*. https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2021/nov/03/nso-group-pegasus-spyware-us-blacklist.

[103] The Guardian. (2021, November 23). *Apple sues Israeli spyware firm NSO Group for surveillance of users*. https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2021/nov/23/apple-sues-israeli-cyber-firm-nso-group.

digital life expands, with Gulf states remaining key clients absent enforceable norms.[104]

Transnational repression extends beyond spyware. In 2019, two former Twitter employees were charged with spying for Saudi Arabia, accessing dissidents' private data, phone numbers, IP addresses, to identify critics.[105] Ali Alzabarah accessed over 6000 accounts, and Ahmad Abouammo infiltrated accounts of Saudi critics.[106]

Saudi Arabia also deployed social media bots post-Khashoggi to spread disinformation.[107] Tamara Kharroub (2022) documented bot-driven 'fake news' sites amplifying pro-regime narratives, while further studies confirmed Saudi bot armies overwhelmed dissent.[108] These operations reflect computational propaganda, where AI manipulates narratives to suppress dissent.

These tools highlight the need for a transnational approach to safeguard rights. If exporters and abusers operate across borders, national actions alone are insufficient. Coalitions of states, tech firms, and activists are needed. For Gulf states, continued use risks reputational damage and erodes trust with allies, potentially impacting partnerships if Western citizens are targeted or democratic norms undermined. This underscores the global politics of AI, where regional AI use shapes international norms and alliances.

8 Authoritarian narratives of AI, and how to contest them

Gulf governments deploy narratives framing AI as neutral, benevolent, and essential for modernisation to justify its extensive use in security. A recent Middle East Democracy Center (MEDC) analysis, Is Artificial Intelligence for Democracy or Against It?, outlines how authoritarian regimes, including those in the Gulf, portray AI as a panacea for governance challenges.[109] These narratives emphasise three themes: efficiency (streamlined services), security (protection from crime/terrorism), and inevitability (AI as the future).[110] By framing AI this way, regimes pre-empt criticism, casting opposition as anti-progress or anti-safety.

For example, Saudi Arabia's deployment of CCTV and drone surveillance in Mecca and Medina for Hajj crowd management justifies extensive monitoring as safety driven.[111] Yet, this infrastructure enables dissident monitoring and public expression control. Similarly, the UAE promotes facial recognition (FR) at airports as a convenience for faster processing while emphasizing its role in catching criminals. These framings depoliticise AI, masking its control functions.

Contesting these narratives begins with exposing AI's non-neutrality, as it reflects deployers' objectives.[112] Civil society and researchers can highlight punitive or arbitrary AI use. For instance, Kuwait's 2023 biometric ID program for Bidoon risks profiling stateless individuals, while Dubai's Oyoon over-polices migrant neighbourhoods, amplifying historical arrest biases. International reports, such as Amnesty International's (2022) documentation of Pegasus spyware targeting activists, further erode claims of benevolent AI. Each case undermines the narrative of AI as purely beneficial.

Another strategy is reframing "security" to include protection from state overreach, aligning with human security principles. For example, true security prevents wrongful imprisonment from FR errors, not just crime. Emphasizing human security, freedom from fear and arbitrary state action, broadens the debate beyond regime-centric definitions.

Transparency offers a critical leverage point. Gulf officials' lip service to AI ethics, e.g., UAE's 2019 AI ethics charter, creates openings to demand accountability. Advocates can call for independent audits to validate ethical claims, framing scrutiny as system improvement rather than antagonism. The UAE's proposed AI ethics boards,

[104] Citizen Lab (2023).

[105] The Guardian. (2022, August 10). *Ex-Twitter employee found guilty of spying on Saudi dissidents*. *The Guardian*.

Wired (6 Nov. 2019), *Twitter Insiders Allegedly Spied for Saudi Arabia*: https://www.wired.com/story/twitter-insiders-saudi-arabia-spy/?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[106] U.S. Justice Department (7 Nov. 2019), Two Former Twitter Employees and a Saudi National Charged as Acting as Illegal Agents of Saudi Arabia: https://www.justice.gov/archives/opa/pr/two-former-twitter-employees-and-saudi-national-charged-acting-illegal-agents-saudi-arabia#:~:text=Ali%20Alzabarah%2C%20Ahmad%20Abouammo%2C%20and,Seattle%2C%20Washington%2C%20on%20Nov.

[107] Reuters. (2018, November 1). *Fake news network vs bots: The online war around Khashoggi killing*. *Reuters*. https://www.reuters.com/article/world/fake-news-network-vs-bots-the-online-war-around-khashoggi-killing-idUSKCN1N63PX/?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[108] Kharroub, T. (2022, February 3), "Mapping digital authoritarianism in the Arab world." *Arab Center Washington DC*:

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[111] France 24. (2025, June 4). *Saudis use AI, drones and thousands of cameras to keep Hajj pilgrims safe*. France 24. https://www.france24.com/en/live-news/20250604-saudis-use-ai-drones-and-thousands-of-cameras-to-keep-hajj-pilgrims-safe?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[112] Feldstein (2019).

if strengthened with international expertise, could ensure genuine oversight.

Engaging public sentiments, despite dissent risks in the Gulf, leverages concerns about dignity and fairness. Highlighting cases of AI errors, e.g., a migrant worker misidentified by Oyoon, can raise awareness of AI's risks. This mirrors global examples, like U.S. campaigns against predictive policing errors that led to local bans.[113]

Freedom House's Freedom on the Net 2023 report labels AI's "repressive power," countering regime narratives by highlighting censorship and surveillance at scale.[114] This terminology, adopted by democracies and rights bodies, filters into local discourse via diaspora media and private networks.

Contesting these narratives involves naming and shaming (documenting abuses), reframing debates (security vs. rights), and pushing governance reforms. Reforms include: (1) mandatory Data Protection Impact Assessments (DPIAs) before deploying systems like Oyoon, as per GDPR models; (2) moratoria on high-risk tools like emotion recognition, following EU bans; and (3) independent oversight bodies to ensure accountability.[115] While Gulf debate is constrained, these efforts can influence elites and cautious policy advisors. Over time, as AI's novelty fades, a balanced view may emerge, mitigating harm.

9 Ethical fault lines: recognition AI, predictive analytics, and autonomy

Facial recognition (FR) technologies in the Gulf raise urgent ethical concerns around consent, accuracy, and proportionality. Studies such as the landmark Gender Shades project by Buolamwini and Gebru (2018) underscore profound disparities. Error rates for FR and gender-recognition systems were as low as 0.8% for light-skinned men but soared to over 20–34% for darker-skinned women.[116] Similar studies confirm that training data skewed toward lighter-skinned, male faces causes systemic bias.[117] In the Gulf, where migrant workers (e.g., South Asians) dominate populations, such biases risk misidentification, leading to wrongful arrests or police harassment, eroding presumed innocence.

Even more ethically fraught is experimentation with emotion recognition or "affect AI" in public settings. These systems, claiming to detect stress or deception via facial micro-expressions, are widely discredited for unreliability and intrusiveness.[118] The European Union's (EU) AI Act (2024) explicitly prohibits real-time emotion recognition in surveillance or workplace environments. Proposals for "ethics sheets" to disclose model weaknesses have emerged globally.[119]

Given these stakes, a moratorium on emotion recognition in Gulf public security is justified. Unlike controlled FR at secure entry points, emotion recognition violates privacy by inferring mental states, risking criminalization of benign behaviours.[120] A narrow, reviewable moratorium, pending independent validation, aligns with EU bans and protects against harm (Marassi, 2025).

Predictive policing, using AI to forecast crime locations or perpetrators, poses well-documented ethical challenges. Algorithms relying on historical data can perpetuate over-policing in certain neighbourhoods, creating self-fulfilling cycles of surveillance.[121] Without transparency, targeted individuals or communities cannot challenge decisions, undermining fairness.[122]

In Gulf societies, marked by citizen-expatriate and ethnic divisions, predictive policing risks deepening discriminatory governance.[123] For example, Dubai's Oyoon system, flagging 319 suspects in 2018, reportedly over-targets migrant-heavy areas like Deira, while Kuwait's 2023 biometric ID program risks profiling Bidoon as "security risks" without recourse. In contrast, U.S. cities like Oakland halted predictive policing after community pushback, a

[113] Richardson, R., Schultz, J. M., and Crawford, K. (2019) "Dirty Data, Bad Predictions." *New York University Law Review Online* 94: 164–183.

[114] Freedom House. (2023). *Freedom on the Net 2023: The Repressive Power of Artificial Intelligence*. Freedom House.https://freedomhouse.org/report/freedom-net/2023/repressive-power-artificial-intelligence?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

[115] Access Now. "Prohibit Emotion Recognition in the AI Act." May 2022. https://www.accessnow.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/05/Prohibit-emotion-recognition-in-the-Artificial-Intelligence-Act.pdf.

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[117] Srinivas, T. S., Goutham, T., and Kumaran, M. S. (2022), "Face Recognition based Smart Attendance System Using IoT", *International Research Journal of Engineering and Technology (IRJET)*: https://www.irjet.net/archives/V9/i3/IRJET-V9I333.pdf.

[118] European Union. (2024/2025). *Artificial Intelligence Act*. OJ L, (2024/1689). Retrieved from EU digital strategy portal: https://eur-lex.europa.eu/eli/reg/2024/1689/oj/eng.

[119] Access Now (2025).

[120] Marassi, S. (14 April 2025), "The Prohibition of AI Emotion Recognition Technologies in the Workplace under the AI Act", *Global Workplace Law & Policy,* https://legalblogs.wolterskluwer.com/global-workplace-law-and-policy/the-prohibition-of-ai-emotion-recognition-technologies-in-the-workplace-under-the-ai-act/?output=pdf.

[121] Ferguson (2017).

[122] Richardson et al. (2019).

[123] NIST. (2019). *Study evaluates effects of race, age, sex on face recognition software*. National Institute of Standards and Technology. https://www.nist.gov/news-events/news/2019/12/nist-study-evaluates-effects-race-age-sex-face-recognition-software?utm_source=chatgpt.com.

mechanism absent in the Gulf's limited civic space.[124] Ethically responsible implementation requires accuracy checks, explainability, and contestability—mechanisms currently absent in Gulf deployments.

To mitigate these ethical fault lines, Gulf states could adopt: (1) mandatory Data Protection Impact Assessments (DPIAs) before deploying FR or predictive systems, as per GDPR models; (2) independent audits with public error reporting to address biases, like migrant misidentification; and (3) moratoria on emotion recognition until validated, following EU standards.[125] Globally, coalitions advocating export controls on high-risk AI, as per Freedom House (2023), could limit proliferation.[126] These steps would align Gulf AI with ethical governance, reducing harm while maintaining public safety.[127]

10 Conclusion

AI is remaking security governance in the Gulf, integrating into existing modalities of centralised authority, techno-optimist modernisation, and security-first governance. This amplifies regime resilience through infrastructures of visibility and prediction, as seen in Qatar's World Cup 2022, Dubai's Oyoon, and Abu Dhabi's Safe City. The novelty lies in the scale and granularity of control: where security forces once monitored plazas, AI now tracks individual faces in crowds; where intelligence services targeted select communications, automated systems scan vast data flows for dissent.

The global politics of AI shapes Gulf trajectories through material and normative inputs. Materially, Gulf AI capabilities rely on international supply chains for hardware, software, and expertise. Geopolitical dynamics, U.S.-China competition, export controls, dictate tool availability. For example, U.S. restrictions on high-end GPUs limit compute access, while U.S. partnerships impose ethical conditions. Normatively, global debates, particularly the EU AI Act, create a backdrop for judging Gulf actions. Gulf states assert "international best practices" to maintain investment credibility yet often avoid enforcement.

This article's case studies, Qatar's World Cup 2022, Dubai's Oyoon, and Abu Dhabi's Safe City, demonstrate AI's intersection with ethics and security. Qatar's 2022 World Cup showcased AI-enabled surveillance, with 15,000 cameras normalising intrusive technologies post-event. Digital rights groups highlight the permanence of this temporary toolkit. Dubai's Oyoon and Abu Dhabi's Safe City treat cities as algorithmically secured fortresses, blending safety with social control. Unanswered questions about error rates and biases, due to opacity, challenge their "success" narratives.

Global vendor ecosystems sustain Gulf surveillance, adapting to constraints like U.S. export controls or NSO Group blacklisting. A structural solution, like a regulatory framework for dual-use AI technologies modelled on the Wassenaar Arrangement, is needed to curb proliferation. The EU AI Act illustrates the global struggle to bind AI to ethical governance. Gulf states selectively adopt norms like UNESCO's AI ethics principles to legitimise practices without enforcement, a form of ethics-washing. This article extends securitisation theory by applying practice-oriented frameworks to GCC cases, documenting how AI institutionalises routine exceptionality. It builds on digital authoritarianism by detailing vendor-state hybrids and surveillance legacies, contributing to critical security studies.

10.1 Future Implications

The Gulf stands at the threshold of global leadership in ethical AI: by investing in auditable, rights-respecting systems, states could catalyse innovation in transparent and accountable policing technologies. Achieving this potential will likely require complementary external incentives, such as EU export standards or responsible-investment frameworks, but the region's trajectory need not mirror its past; it can champion a model of technological modernisation grounded in dignity and oversight rather than repression. Realising this vision requires a detailed political programme: one that makes AI deployments contestable through robust oversight and appeal mechanisms, auditable via independent and transparent external reviews, and bounded by clear legal frameworks defining permissible use. Such a model would govern every layer of the AI ecosystem, inputs, compute, data, expertise, and outputs, embedding accountability and legitimacy into the very architecture of technological governance.

For Gulf states, aligning AI with human rights and sustainable security is pragmatic, not just moral. Young, tech-savvy populations will increasingly demand agency and privacy as global cultural exposure grows. States adopting legitimate, rights-respecting AI may achieve greater stability than those entrenching automated authoritarianism, which history shows falters when societies feel stifled. In conclusion, AI's dual potential in the Gulf, enhancing human development or perfecting tyranny, depends on institutional and political choices. These choices can be shaped by evidence-based research, international cooperation, and public voices, however constrained. The outcome should

[124] Richardson et al. (2019).

[125] Access Now (2025).

[126] Freedom House (2023).

[127] SMEX. "AI Investments and Surveillance Risks in the Gulf." 2025. https://smex.org/gulf-ai-surveillance-2025.

prioritise innovation that empowers citizens over surveillance and control. Practically, this requires three conditions for security-AI: ex ante Data Protection Impact Assessments (DPIAs), independent audits with public error reporting, and time-bounded authorisations with sunset clauses tied to rights impacts.

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Declarations

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